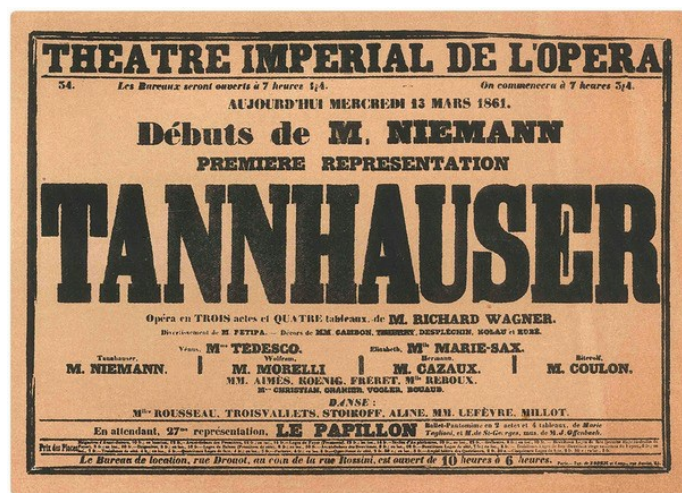


his mother lived with actor and painter Ludwig Geyer, who may have been Richard's biological father. Originally attracted to writing drama, around the age of 15 Wagner discovered his musical vocation, inspired by hearing Beethoven's Ninth Symphony. Studying composition in Leipzig, he wrote a juvenile symphony and various keyboard works, but his ambitions soon focused exclusively on opera. From the outset he wrote his own libretti, regarding himself as a dramatist as well as a composer.



TANNHÄUSER POSTER

This poster announces the premiere of Wagner's Tannhäuser at the Opéra de Paris in 1861. The opera touches on the conflict between sexual and spiritual love.

## Turmoil and instability

Wagner had completed two unsuccessful operas, Die Feen and Das Liebesverbot, by 1836, when he married Minna Planer, an actress. She left him, briefly, for another man. Although they were reconciled, it was not an easy marriage. Wagner became